

THE SHOEBOX

Mundane items and memorabilia

Why am I holding onto random items like bottle caps, candy wrappers, or tea boxes? And why are my friends doing it too?

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The shoebox

A cardboard shoebox – filled with memorabilia like old tickets, bottle caps, handwritten notes, and photographs – might seem trivial to some, but for me, it represents a memory capsule: a collection of personal artifacts imbued with history and sentiment. Through this paper, I want to see through my shoebox and the items within it from an anthropological perspective, examining how such an object, though seemingly mundane, actively shapes memory, identity, and human experience.

As a personal object, I looked through 4 main key ideas in the anthropology of material course. The most obvious is the agency of objects when a mundane object can influence the owner's actions. Then the ontological turn of the object, the relationality and temporal of material objects in life. Furthermore, the cluster of items within it reflect the entanglements through gifts, show out the value of those objects but in contrast the ephemerality of material culture when they could be replaced.

The agency of the shoebox

I got this shoebox within the first month of moving to Belgium in 2023. At first, it was simply a place to store flight and train tickets alongside some receipts. Combined with my habit of gathering small memorable items from gifts, traveling trips and special occasions, it became a repository. Over time, the items inside started filling up with postcards, gifts, bottle caps, small photos, and vice versa. By this time, it has been filled to the brim with many random items.

The items in the box are tied to the moments and people in my life, sometimes with a very specific experience. For example: the bottle caps of the craft beers I had with some friends in Romania, the tea boxes from a trip to Dinant, or a napkin printed with birds from the second Christmas dinner in 2023, I can name them all. Imagine they all have a different color shade representing the actants, and each linked with the specific memories drawn in that same color. Perhaps they are all color-less to me if it was the same item outside of the box, but within the box, they are a collection with different colors. Every time I open and go through these items, it feels like I was reliving the memories.

Hoskin (2006) observed that "the proposed equivalence between the agency of persons and that of things challenges the boundaries of individual identity and collective representation" provides a compelling entry point to explore the agency of the shoebox. This perspective invites me to examine not only how such a

simple cardboard box interacts with the material world but also why it holds my fascination, and what could be revealed about my phenomenological experiences.

The shoebox's agency lies in its ability to drive me to interact with it. I often open it to reorganize its contents – my ritual of reliving memories – or to add new items. And sometimes, I open the box just to find something 'cool' and show it off to a friend. This process transforms the shoebox into a storytelling device, a mnemonic as described by Hoskins (1998). By storing items with sentimental significance, the shoebox extends beyond being a container; it becomes an active participant in my social and emotional life.

On one hand, the acts of looking through old bottle caps, handling tickets, or re-reading handwritten notes prompt my memories and emotions. It links me to people, places, and moments that have shaped my life.

On the other hand, the concept of object agency is further reflected in my decision to keep seemingly mundane items like bottle caps or receipts, these objects becoming "invested" with personal meaning, symbolizing a form of relationality (Newell 2014). This transformation into an (un)fetish occurs when they are personalized and rendered inalienable, marking them as extensions of memory or identity rather than mere objects. Without the box as a shell, the habit of collecting those items for sure still happens, but they might lie scattered around and easily be forgotten.

The agency of the shoebox was not only the literal consciousness when I repeatedly go through it, but also how it holds the items that can evoke memories, emotions and identify information. It has an active participation in my social life.

The ontology turns – physical – unphysical – and again physical

The shoebox perhaps is a memory capsule, a symbolic artifact that holds what is important to me in the current stage of life. Unlike family heirlooms, which often carry generational significance, my shoebox is transient, adaptable, and replaceable. This reflects a unique ontology of material culture where objects are tied to personal, rather than collective, narratives.

The items inside the shoebox, although insignificant to others, hold immense sentimental value for me. Each object anchors a specific personal moment, a small piece of my life's history collected from time to time as a way of being (Moutu 2007). These items are not monumental artifacts; rather, they are everyday ephemera – items that would typically be discarded or forgotten. However, placing within the shoebox, these items take on new significance. They embody my desire to resist the natural tendency to dispose of the past, symbolizing a desire to hold onto memories that might otherwise fade.

I was also looking through other memory-preserving practices of artifacts such as scrapbooks, time capsules, or photo albums – universal human desire to anchor identity in tangible artifacts. The common ground between these items to me is how personalized they were, and they reflected a particular stage of someone or a group of people's lives. Although we have many ways and tools to process these practices, unlike most other living organisms, we tend to try capturing nonphysical events via physical items.

I think of how my mother values the old analog photo albums – when it was expensive for her to get a film photo washed out – every photo was very precious, they can represent different scenes within the event it was taken and reshaping collective memory (Banks and Vokes 2010). Analog photographs serve as both

memory keepers and archival artifacts (Banks and Vokes 2010). When placed, a photograph takes on social significance and meaning, reflecting its role within relationships. As is often so in the case of albums, to fulfill their social role, the albums must be in the right hands, both literally and metaphorically (Edwards 2012).

In today's digital age, memory preservation often takes the form of photographs, videos, and social media posts. These tools offer convenience and accessibility but lack the tactile intimacy of physical artifacts. I can have hundreds of photos on my phone for an event, but one bottle cap can represent those photos to me. It seems like how we used to squeeze unphysical moments into a physical piece of paper – the photo – and now I am squeezing those pixels on the photos back to physical items.

Material temporality and Fragility of Memory

Thus, the shoebox holds my memories, it was not a permanent material. I understand how temporal this box could be, at the same time, the memories it holds within. The first ever box was when I was in middle school back in Vietnam. It was a branded shoebox that I found too good to be thrown away. It became the storage for those items that I have kept around me. The box itself stood no value, but when store the items, it became personal.

While I preserve memories by collecting and storing the items, the materiality of the shoebox – cardboard as I mentioned above – suggests fragility and impermanence. And when I replace the box when it crumbled, it serves as a reminder that the act of memory preservation is ongoing, continuously adapting to the changing conditions of life.

That very first box did get replaced on the last year of my high school, when it became too old and wrinkled due to being opened and closed many times through the years. The replacement box was also another shoebox, just the box got replaced, all the items inside got transferred to the new one. This reminded me of the Vietnamese idiom: “binh moi ruou cu” – translated as “old wine in a new bottle”. The box was just a temporal shell for memories, it has no personal tie to me without the items within it. The cardboard object is inherently vulnerable to deterioration and eventual replaceable. This reflects the impermanence of both physical objects and memories, highlighting the interplay between preservation and decay that characterizes material culture.

Before moving to Europe for my study, I decided to leave the box back in Vietnam with all the items in it. To me, it holds the memories I had of that stage of my life. It was not only because the items were just valuable in the nonphysical aspects and a bit too much for the luggage I needed to carry here, but also because I wanted to keep the version of myself safe and sound back at home. At this moment, there are two parallel shoeboxes: one in Vietnam holds memories before I traveled here, and the other one that gradually filled up with the memories I had after moving here. During the reflection paper review with other colleagues, someone asked me if I would consider both shoeboxes are the same thing, and my first response was perhaps not if I move back to Vietnam, I might would just keep both boxes separated. But now when looking back, maybe in the future, I might merge them together, representing all the memories before the new stage of my life.

By going through the shoebox from time to time checking the items, I can revisit and reconstruct memories, I know that each act of preservation is temporary, our memories are just gathered scattered moments, and the items help me to organize them. Although, maybe after a while, those might become false memories. Moutu (2007) highlights how time plays a crucial role in shaping collection as a way of being. The act of collecting involves a synthetic process of assembling temporal fragments, creating an illusion of continuity that is inherently tied to a sense of loss. This loss, rather than being merely negative, serves a productive function in defining the temporal nature of collections. And when I cannot recall anything about a specific item anymore, the item then will be taken out of the box. The consequence comes after is that there will be space for newer items to be placed in.

Relationality and Object-Person connection

Moutu (2007) also describes Baudrillard's theory of collecting as rooted in a strong sense of individualism, where the act of collection becomes a "discourse directed to oneself." This perspective ties the practice to a fetishization of objects, shaped by a perception of temporal continuity that is mediated through the collected items.

The practice of keeping items inside the shoebox establishes a relationship between me and the events. These objects signify – each ticket recalls a journey, each note a friendship, each bottle caps a gathering or moment of celebration. In this sense, the shoebox acts as an extension of my identity, symbolizing the enduring importance of memory in forming and reaffirming the self.

Tim Ingold (2021) argues that memory is like an inner cabinet of the mind, wherever we go and whatever we do, we carry the contents of memory with us. My memories with others are being imported into those items. And these objects help to bring out the memories to me when I go through them, reviewing the relation between objects and my connections.

By maintaining the shoebox, I preserve my memories, reaffirm relationships, and share experiences. I compare this with relational ontology – where objects are seen as interconnected with human lives and are not isolated in their meaning (Herva 2009). The shoebox itself, though its role in my life, becomes a symbol of relational ontology, embodying the interconnectedness of people and objects. It then reinforces the notion that objects derive meaning from the lives they touch.

I asked some of my friends about their own experience with this same type of practice, most of them – mainly are female – have at least one. I also have vivid memories during school time that some of my classmates had the same type of boxes which they kept random stuff. Furthermore, I went to browse through the internet – seeing what others' ideas about this kind of object – turned out, it was more common than I expected. They also mentioned their shoebox, maybe cigar box, a fancy chocolate tin box, vice versa, as the treasure box. The items inside are – pretty much – similar: an old library card from school, football or concert tickets, stamps, postcards, and vice versa. Unexpectedly, some said theirs expanded to a whole basement, attic, a room in their house, but I find that then the object lost its ability to be mobile and now is harder to be replaceable.

Conclusion

Ultimately, this shoebox serves as a testament to the enduring power of memory and the way ordinary objects can become extraordinary through the stories they encapsulate. Viewed through an anthropological lens, the shoebox becomes a piece of material culture that embodies my desire to preserve, remember, and make sense of the past in an ever-changing world. The practice of keeping such a box reflects the ways in which humans create meaning and continuity in their lives, highlighting the essential role of objects in the construction of personal and collective identity, preserving the essence of who we are in the ordinary artifacts we choose to keep close. In its fragility and impermanence, the shoebox reminds me of the delicate balance between preservation and change, capturing the essence of what it means to be human.

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